proved lethally expert at ambushing forces travelling to supply or relieve these strongpoints by road, the Legion formed its first parachute battalions to airdrop men into the war zone. The Legion carried out 156 combat jumps in the course of the war. The brutal fighting, marked by massacre and atrocity on both sides, culminated in the decisive defeat of the French at the Battle of Dien Bien Phu in 1954. In total, some 10,000 legionnaires died in the Indochina War, with 30,000 more wounded or taken prisoner. It was a disaster for the Legion, and just as the war in Indochina came to an end, a new conflict opened in Algeria, the Legion's traditional home.



Foreign Legion insignia
This ringed, seven-flamed grenade was adopted as the Legion's insignia in 1963.

ALGERIA AND BEYOND

From 1954 a nationalist movement, the FLN, mounted a guerrilla and terrorist campaign to drive the French out of Algeria. Once more the Legion was at the core of France's military riposte. The 1st Régiment Etrangère Parachutiste (REP – Foreign Legion Parachute Regiment) played a leading role in the controversial Battle of Algiers in 1957, a ruthlessly effective crackdown on FLN terrorists operating in the city's casbah quarter, which was accomplished partly through the routine use of torture.

When in 1961 French President General de Gaulle decided to grant Algeria independence, 1st REP was prominent in supporting a coup attempt mounted by disaffected French generals. The coup was abortive, however, as most of the Legion, and of the French Army in general, refused to support it. The 1st REP was permanently disbanded in punishment for its act of rebellion.

On 24 October 1962, the Legion left Algeria for good, relocating to Aubagne, in the south of France. It might have appeared that the Legion had no future, but there was plentiful need for highly trained forces to project French power around the world. The 2nd REP, based in Corsica, established an impressive reputation as a rapid intervention force, and elements of the Legion were sent to fight against Iraq in 1991 and more recently against the Taliban in Afghanistan.

BATTLE OF DIEN BIEN PHU

In the winter of 1953–54, France flew in some 16,000 troops to construct and occupy a series of strongpoints around an airstrip at Dien Bien Phu, in a remote valley near the border between Vietnam and Laos. The Foreign Legion provided the majority of the soldiers, settling into their fortified positions with support facilities that included a well-staffed brothel. By March 1954, Viet Minh commander General Vo Nguyen Giap had encircled Dien Bien Phu with some 50,000 men, installing heavy artillery on the surrounding hills.

Defeat of the French

The French believed that they could keep their men supplied by air and that their firepower would destroy the Viet Minh. But Giap's artillery quickly put the airstrip out of action, and resupply by paradrop was made hazardous by anti-aircraft fire. Two outlying strong points, Beatrice and Isabelle, were overrun on 13–14 March, but then the defence stiffened. Legion volunteers were paradropped in as reinforcements, some making their first ever parachute jump to come to their comrades' aid. Their courage was wasted, however. On 7–8 May the final French positions were overwhelmed. Almost half of the 4,000 defenders killed at Dien Bien Phu were French legionnaires.

Parachute drop into Dien Bien Phu
Legionnaires parachute into the fortified valley of Dien Bien Phu during the disasterous Indochina War, 1953.

